

Dugong and manatees

Order Sirenia

Amazonian manatee

Trichechus inunguis

- ↔ Up to 10 ft (3 m)
- 📍 Amazon basin
- ⊗ Vulnerable

Sirenians, or sea cows, are seal-like aquatic mammals related to elephants. They feed on water plants in swamps and shallow coastal seas. The only fully freshwater sirenian, this manatee feeds in the extensive floodwaters of the Amazon river system during the rainy season.



Other species

- **Dugong** *Dugong dugon* » p304
- **West Indian manatee** *Trichechus manatus* » p67

Elephants

Order Proboscidea

African forest elephant

Loxodonta cyclotis

- ↔ 10–13 ft (3–4 m)
- 📍 W. and C. Africa
- ⊗ Not known

Although similar to the African savanna elephant (*Loxodonta africana*), this species is smaller in size and has smaller, oval ears and darker skin as well. Compared with the savanna elephant, the African forest elephant's tusks are harder and straighter, adaptations that

allow it to push through the dense vegetation of its tropical forest habitat. Mature males are known to have tusks that almost reach the ground. The forest elephant eats more fruit than the bush elephant and is an important agent of seed dispersal.

Other species

- **African savanna elephant** *Loxodonta africana* » pp202–03
- **Asian elephant** *Elephas maximus* » p259

Hyraxes

Order Hyracoidea

Southern tree hyrax

Dendrohyrax arboreus

- ↔ 16–28 in (40–70 cm)
- 📍 E. and Southern Africa
- ⊗ Common

Hyraxes are small, stocky mammals that resemble guinea pigs, but they are actually most closely allied to elephants. This East African species lives mainly in forests, where it forages in the trees at night for fruit, leaves, and other plant matter. It rarely comes down to the ground, retreating to tree-holes by day to avoid predators such as lions, jackals, hyenas, and eagles.

Other species

- **Rock hyrax** *Procavia capensis* » p253



Armadillos

Order Cingulata

Giant armadillo

Priodontes maximus

- ↔ 30–39 in (75–100 cm)
- 📍 N. and C. South America
- ⊗ Vulnerable

By far the biggest armadillo, this widespread species has 11–13 bands of hinged plates on its body, with others covering its head, neck, and tail. It uses its long, curved front claws to dig for small prey such as ants and worms, but will also eat small snakes and lizards.



Big hairy armadillo

Chaetophractus villosus

- ↔ 9–16 in (22–40 cm)
- 📍 S. South America
- ⊗ Common

Named for the long, coarse hair that protrudes from between the plates of its body armor, this is one of the most common armadillos in southern South America. When threatened, it protects its soft underside by pressing its body into the ground.

Other species

- **Six-banded armadillo** *Euphractus sexcinctus* » p117

Sloths and anteaters

Order Pilosa

Maned sloth

Bradypus torquatus

- ↔ 18–20 in (45–50 cm)
- 📍 E. South America
- ⊗ Vulnerable

Restricted to the coastal rainforests of eastern Brazil, this is one of four species of three-toed sloth. Like all sloths, it is a leaf-eater that spends nearly all its time hanging from the branches of trees by its strong, hooklike

claws. Green algae growing on its coat camouflages it well from predators, but if attacked, it lashes out with its claws.

Other species

- **Giant anteater** *Myrmecophaga tridactyla* » p116
- **Hoffman's two-toed sloth** *Choloepus hoffmanni* » p79
- **Silky anteater** *Cyclopes didactylus* » p86

Collared anteater

Tamandua tetradactyla

- ↔ 21–35 in (53–88 cm)
- 📍 N. and E. South America
- ⊗ Least concern

Although similar to the giant anteater in both appearance and feeding habits, this smaller, more agile species often feeds in the trees of the tropical rainforest. It uses its strong prehensile tail to grip the branches as it breaks into the nests of tree-living ants, termites, and bees with its long claws, extracting them with a wormlike tongue that may be up to 16 in (40 cm) long.